FIRST-PERSON

'THE NATIONAL TEAM MUST COME FIRST'

Khalid Jamil, coach of the national men's football team, talks about what he thinks are the problems plaguing Indian football

The biggest challenge I am facing is the unavailability of players. Clubs are either not releasing players or recalling players after releasing them for national duty, or releasing them so late that I barely get any meaningful training time with the squad. What I need is continuity—a fixed group of players and sufficient time to work with them. Since taking charge, I have conducted four camps. Every time, I had a different set of players. How can anyone realistically expect consistent results? The national team must come first. Players also have a responsibility. They should speak to their clubs and say that they want to be available for the national team once the domestic season is over.

For example, Bengaluru FC initially did not release a player I wanted. I called their CEO, Parth Jindal, and he made arrangements, saying that serving the nation was paramount. I believe every club owner would support the national team if approached. Then, one night, I called footballer Vikram Pratap Singh and asked him to join the camp, and he complied. We need that commitment. People often point to problems such as inadequate scouting, weak grassroots structures and the lack of school football. They are right. We need better scouting systems and a stronger grassroots ecosystem. At the same time, our players need more international matches. That exposure is equally important for their development. As for the next World Cup, we have to improve. But immediate problems need to be resolved.

"I hope I have a stable pool of players and the means to build a settled team. The AIFF has been very supportive so far"



I am starting another national camp soon. I have spoken to some players and will work with them. I hope a solution can be found so that I have a stable pool of players and the opportunity to build a settled team.

As far as the AIFF is concerned, I have faced no interference. Everyone, including president Kalyan Chaubey, has been supportive. Whatever recent results have been, the responsibility is mine. ■

— As told to Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

most young Indians, the answer is no.

Unlike cricket, the returns in football are neither immediate nor guaranteed. Still, for decades, the game offered financial security through government employment under sports quotas. Those opportunities have diminished greatly and many promising players struggle to justify pursuing football professionally.

There is another worrying trend—the absence of new footballing icons who can captivate a generation and generate public interest. For nearly two decades, Indian football rode on the shoulders of Bhaichung Bhutia and later Sunil Chhetri. Their charisma kept fans interested and convinced sponsors that football had a market in India. But the pipeline expected to produce their successors failed to deliver. The shortage compelled Chhetri to reverse his international retirement at the age of 40 to bolster India's campaign in the AFC Asian Cup 2027 qualifiers.

Pradyumna Tembhekar, a team doctor for ISL team Jamshedpur FC and India's FIFA ambassador, has heard his share of jibes about Indian football. "A Canadian ambassador told me that even if there are 128 teams in the World Cup, India [still] won't make it," he says.

IN FOOTBALL WE TRUST

Ironic though it may sound, several populous swathes of India nurse a passion for the game. Football fills stadiums in Kolkata, unites villages in Kerala, dominates evenings in Goa and is deeply embedded in the Northeast's sporting culture, especially in Mizoram and Manipur. Every year, thousands of children dream of wearing the national jersey.

Indian football is also seeing some positive change. Residential academies like Tata Football Academy in Jamshedpur, Minerva, Bengaluru FC soccer schools supported by JSW Sports and the Reliance Foundation Young Champs in Navi Mumbai are ensuring the next generation of players get technical knowledge, appropriate nutrition, fitness and education. Talented young players from these academies are recruited by ISL teams.

AIFF is drawing inspiration from the Cabo Verde's diaspora model and allowing clubs to field one Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) player in their squad. However, not everyone is convinced. "We don't have as many players in the diaspora," notes Reddy, adding that FIFA rules about national team representation are stringent.

Reversing the decline in Indian football will mean rebuilding it from the ground up—year-round scouting, integrated football schools, a predictable competition calendar and sticking to a long-term roadmap. For too long, Indian football has searched for shortcuts to success. The countries overtaking it offer a lesson: in football, there are none. ■